Session 1: Job Roles & Metrics

Before you come to class

This pre-read takes about 25 minutes, and its one big idea is simple: the same company data gets read in very different ways, depending on whose desk you sit at.

Read it once, slowly. Don't try to memorise the roles. Instead, notice the **one question** each role keeps asking. In class, we will practise turning data into answers to those questions.

You don't need Google Sheets for this one. Just read, think, and try the four warm-up questions at the end.

Two words you will see often. **Data** is information written down in rows and columns, like a school attendance register. A **metric** is a number with a name that tells you whether something is going well, like "attendance %" or "runs per over".

1. Your job decides which numbers you look at

Imagine a small pizza shop. It keeps one big sheet with every order. Each row is one order, and the column names (called **headers**) are: order_id, date, pizza_type, price, ingredient_cost, delivery_minutes, and how_they_found_us.

Four people open the **same sheet**, but each asks a different question:

Person	Their question	The number they pick
Owner	Are we making money?	Price minus ingredient cost, added up
Chef	Which pizza should I make more of tomorrow?	Orders per pizza type
Delivery rider	Are we late?	Average delivery minutes
Flyer designer	Which flyer actually brings new people?	New customers per flyer

Same sheet. Four questions. Four different numbers. Nobody is wrong. Each one is looking through their own window.

A company is a big pizza shop. Every role is a different window. When you take a job, you are really learning four things:

1. **The question** your role is paid to answer.
2. **The data** where the answer hides.
3. **The numbers** (metrics) that show if things are going well.
4. **The person** who has to act on what you find, and how to explain it so they will.

The rest of this pre-read walks through those four things for eight roles.

2. Meet the eight roles

Each role is built around one main job, which fits in one verb. Here is the quick view first, then a closer look at each. Job titles differ from company to company, so treat these as the common meaning. The company examples are imagined, to show the kind of work, not real decisions.

Role	One-word verb	What they own	Judged on	Example at a real company
Founder's Office	Figure out	New, fuzzy bets	Did the big question get answered?	At Mamaearth: "Should we launch a men's grooming range?"
Chief of Staff	Orchestrate	The leadership operating rhythm (the regular meetings and follow-ups that run the company)	Whether the company gets things done, and how effective the CEO is	At Swiggy: running the weekly review that keeps city heads lined up on the quarter's goals
Program Manager	Ship	A big project that many teams work on	On-time, on-scope delivery (finished when promised, with everything promised)	At Urban Company: going live in 5 new cities in 90 days
Product Manager	Build	What the app or website does for its users	Do users use it, and do they come back?	At Zoho: finding which features free-trial users actually use
Growth Manager	Grow	The whole customer journey: try, buy, come back	More customers and repeat orders for every ₹ spent	At boAt: getting one-time earphone buyers to buy a second product
Acquisition Manager	Acquire	Bringing in new customers from ads and partners	New customers, and the cost of each new customer	At Freshworks: finding the cheapest way to get a company to ask for a demo
Category Manager	Own the shelf	One category's P&L (profit and loss: money in minus money out)	Category sales, margin and availability	At Meesho: owning the "Kurtis" category, with its sellers, prices and offers
Demand Planner	Forecast	How much of each item to buy and stock	Forecast accuracy, empty shelves and unsold stock	At Licious: deciding how much chicken to cut for Sunday

New words in that table are explained in the Jargon Buster near the end.

1. Founder's Office

What they do. A small team that sits next to the founder and takes on whatever problem matters most right now. One month it is "should we open in Pune?" The next it is "why are costs rising?". They are generalists, which means they learn a little of everything.

Data they open. Everything: sales, costs, hiring, customers. It usually lives in many messy files, and part of the job is pulling it together.

What good looks like. A one-page answer with a clear recommendation that the founder can read in five minutes.

Example. The founder asks, "Should we launch in Pune?" The Founder's Office compares orders, delivery cost and customer interest in Pune against a city already launched, then says yes, no, or "not yet, and here is why".

2. Chief of Staff

What they do. The right hand of a senior leader, often the CEO. They run the company's rhythm: weekly reviews, quarterly goals, and follow-up on who promised what. The Founder's Office solves a problem and moves on. The Chief of Staff keeps the machine running every week. Some companies use the two titles for the same job.

Data they open. Numbers from every team, a goal tracker (a sheet listing each goal, its target and progress), and the budget sheet.

What good looks like. A one-page scorecard in red, amber and green, plus a list of stuck items with a named owner and a date.

Example. In the monthly review, the Chief of Staff shows six company goals. Three are green, two are amber, and one is red: customer support replies are too slow. Next to it sits a name and a date for the fix.

3. Program Manager

What they do. Makes sure one big project, involving many teams, finishes on time and within budget. Think "launch in five new cities in 90 days". They don't build the product or sell it. They make sure the teams that do are not waiting on each other.

Data they open. Project plans, task lists with owners and due dates, budget sheets, and a risk list (things that could go wrong).

What good looks like. A clear status: on track, at risk, or late. Delays are flagged early, with a fix attached.

Example. For the five-city launch, the tracker shows each city, how many tasks are done, and how many days late it is. Pune is 6 days late because the warehouse lease is pending, so the Program Manager escalates it today.

4. Product Manager

What they do. Decides what the app or website should do, in what order, and why. They are the voice of the user inside the company.

Data they open. What users do inside the product (taps, searches, purchases), a **funnel** (the steps a user takes, narrowing at each step like a funnel), user feedback, and results of tests.

What good looks like. Linking a product change to a change in user behaviour: "We removed one step at checkout, and more people paid."

Example. Imagine 1,000 people open a food app. 400 add food to the cart. 200 reach the payment page. 100 pay. The Product Manager sees that half of the people at payment don't finish, and tests a simpler payment screen.

5. Growth Manager

What they do. Looks across the whole customer journey (getting customers, getting them to try the product, getting them to come back) and runs many small experiments to grow faster.

Data they open. What each customer did and when, campaign results, experiment results, and **cohorts** (groups of customers who joined in the same month, followed over time).

What good looks like. An experiment with a before-and-after number, and a decision: scale it up, or stop.

Example. Offer ₹50 off the second order to new customers. After 30 days, check how many of them ordered again compared with those who got no offer. If the offer group clearly orders again more, scale it.

6. Acquisition Manager

What they do. Has a narrower job than Growth. They bring in new customers through paid ads (Instagram, Google), partners, and influencers, and they are judged on how much each new customer costs.

Data they open. A campaign table with headers like date, channel, spend, impressions, clicks, signups, and orders.

What good looks like. Channels compared on equal footing, and a clear call on where to move the budget.

Example. Instagram: ₹1,00,000 spent, 200 new customers, so ₹500 per customer. Google: ₹1,00,000 spent, 400 new customers, so ₹250 per customer. Google looks twice as good. A careful Acquisition Manager also checks

whether Google customers come back, because cheap and loyal are not the same thing.

7. Category Manager

What they do. Runs one product category as if it were a small business inside the company, such as "Dairy" or "Kurtis". They decide which products to stock or list, at what price, with which offers, and from which suppliers or sellers. They answer for the category's P&L: the money it earns minus the money it spends.

Data they open. Sales by product, price and discount, **margin** (the share of the selling price left after paying for the product), and availability (how often the item was in stock when customers looked).

What good looks like. A clear call for each product: keep, promote, re-price, or drop, backed by sales, margin and availability numbers.

Example. Imagine the "Kurtis" category on Meesho. Sales are up 20%, but margin is falling because of heavy discounts. The Category Manager checks which sellers discount the most and which products still earn good margin, then moves the offers to those products.

8. Demand Planner

What they do. Predicts how much of each product will sell, so the company orders the right amount. Too much and money sits on shelves or the product expires. Too little and customers find an empty shelf and leave.

Data they open. Daily sales by product and location, stock at the start and end of each day, **lead time** (days between placing an order and getting it), and a calendar of festivals and offers.

What good looks like. A forecast with reasons ("Sundays sell 50% more") and a list of what to order, how much, and by when.

Example. A supermarket sells about 200 packets of milk a day, and 300 on Sundays. The supplier takes 2 days to deliver. The Demand Planner must place the order two days early, with enough to cover the Sunday jump.

3. What each role cares about: the metrics

Metrics come in families. Use this table as a map, not a memory test: when a role has a question, find its family, and you will find the numbers that answer it. You will compute many of these in the coming sessions. In the last column, short names are used, so "Growth" means the Growth Manager, "Category" means the Category Manager, and so on.

Family	Metric (and its short form)	Plain-English meaning	What to look for	Roles that care most
Acquisition	Traffic / Visits	How many people opened the app or site	Is it growing? Where from?	Growth, Acquisition
	CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost)	₹ spent to get one new customer	Going up or down over time?	Acquisition, Growth, Founder's Office
	ROAS (Return on Ad Spend)	Sales earned for every ₹1 spent on ads	Above or below 1? Which channel is best?	Acquisition, Growth
	Conversion Rate	% of visitors who actually buy	Where do people drop off?	Product, Growth, Acquisition
	Organic vs Paid mix	Free customers vs paid-for ones	Too dependent on ads?	Growth, Acquisition, Founder's Office
	Referral rate / K-factor	New users each user brings in	Is the product spreading on its own?	Growth

Family	Metric (and its short form)	Plain-English meaning	What to look for	Roles that care most
Revenue and order economics	GMV (Gross Merchandise Value)	Total value of everything sold	The headline "size" number	Everyone
	Net Revenue	What the company actually keeps	The real income number, not just a big-looking one	Founder's Office, Category
	AOV (Average Order Value)	Average ₹ per order	Rising = good; falling = discount-led?	Category, Growth
	Units per order (basket size)	Items in a typical order	Is cross-selling (suggesting extra items) working?	Category, Product
	Take Rate (marketplaces)	% commission the platform keeps	Enough to cover costs?	Founder's Office
	Gross Margin %	% left after the cost of the goods	Is each product actually profitable?	Category, Founder's Office
Unit economics	Contribution Margin (CM per order)	Profit on one order after costs that grow with every order, like packing and delivery	Positive or negative per order?	Founder's Office, Category
	CAC Payback	Months to earn back the cost of winning a customer	Shorter = healthier	Founder's Office, Growth, Acquisition
	LTV (Lifetime Value)	Total profit from a customer over their lifetime	High enough vs CAC?	Growth, Founder's Office
	LTV : CAC ratio	Value of a customer ÷ cost to win them	Rule of thumb: 3:1 is healthy	Founder's Office, Growth, Acquisition
	Burn rate	Cash spent per month	How fast is money disappearing?	Founder's Office, Chief of Staff
	Runway	Months of cash left	The survival clock	Founder's Office, Chief of Staff
Retention and engagement	Repeat Rate	% of customers who order again	The loyalty number	Growth, Category
	Cohort Retention (M1 / M3)	% of one month's new users still active 1 or 3 months later	Does the curve flatten or crash to zero?	Growth, Product, Founder's Office
	Churn Rate	% of customers who stop	How big is the leak?	Growth, Product
	Order Frequency	Orders per customer per month	Is it becoming a habit?	Growth, Category
	DAU / MAU and Stickiness	Daily active users ÷ monthly active users: how many of your monthly users show up each day	Daily habit or occasional?	Product, Growth
	Reactivation rate	% of dormant (sleeping) users won back	Can you revive sleeping customers?	Growth
	Activation rate	% of new users who do the key first action, like placing a first order	Do new users "get it" quickly?	Product, Growth
	Feature adoption	% of users who use a given feature	Is the new feature actually used?	Product

Family	Metric (and its short form)	Plain-English meaning	What to look for	Roles that care most
Supply and inventory	Availability (in-stock rate)	% of time an item is in stock when customers look for it	Are we losing sales to empty shelves?	Category, Demand Planner
	Days of cover	How many days current stock will last at today's selling speed	Too low = risk of running out; too high = cash stuck	Demand Planner, Category
	Forecast accuracy	How close the guess was to what really sold	Is the guess usually too high or too low?	Demand Planner
	Unsold (dead) stock %	Share of stock that is not selling	Is cash stuck on shelves?	Demand Planner, Category, Founder's Office
Execution	Milestones on time	% of project steps finished by their due date	Which steps are slipping?	Program Manager, Chief of Staff
	Budget used vs planned	Money spent so far compared with the plan	Overspending early?	Program Manager, Chief of Staff, Founder's Office
	Goals on track	% of company goals on pace to hit their target	How many are red?	Chief of Staff

4. Same company, same bad Monday, eight different questions

Imagine a food-delivery company. On Monday morning, orders are down 10% compared with last Monday: 90,000 instead of 100,000. If the average order is ₹300, that is about ₹30 lakh less sales in one day. Everybody gets a message from the founder. Here is what each role does first.

Role	First question	First thing they check
Founder's Office	Is this a blip or a trend, and does it change what the founder should do this week?	Orders for the last 8 Mondays, and what the drop means for sales and cash
Chief of Staff	Which company goal does this hurt, and who is already fixing it?	The weekly goal tracker: orders against target
Program Manager	Did something we launched last week cause this?	The project calendar and the list of app releases
Product Manager	Did something break or confuse people in the app?	The funnel (open app, add to cart, pay), compared with last Monday
Growth Manager	Did we get fewer new customers, or did old customers order less?	Orders split into new customers and repeat customers
Acquisition Manager	Did an ad campaign stop or get more expensive?	Spend, clicks and signups by channel, compared with last week
Category Manager	Did a big category sell less, or sell at lower prices?	Sales, price and availability by category, compared with last Monday
Demand Planner	Were popular restaurants or items unavailable?	Items out of stock and restaurants closed, by city

Notice what happened. Eight people looked at the same drop and opened eight different views of the data. Each one might find a different cause, and each might be right.

This is why companies need all these roles, and why someone (often the Chief of Staff or Founder's Office) has to pull the answers together into one story. Your skill is not just calculating. It is knowing **which window to open first**.

5. D2C, Marketplace and SaaS: how the same role changes

The same job title feels different depending on **how the company makes money**. There are three common kinds. You will meet all three in this course.

D2C (Direct-to-Consumer)

A brand that makes its own products and sells them straight to customers through its own website or app, not through other shops. Examples: Mamaearth, boAt, Licious, Lenskart.

How it earns. It sells a product for more than it costs to make, ship and advertise. **Unit economics** means checking this profit for one single order.

Example. A boAt earphone sells for ₹1,000. Making and shipping it costs ₹600. Advertising to win that customer cost ₹250. What is left is ₹150 per order. If the buyer returns it, the profit can vanish.

Analysis expected. Profit per order, repeat purchases, cost of winning a customer, returns, and stock levels.

Marketplace

A platform that connects buyers and sellers. It usually does not own the goods. It takes a small cut, called a **commission**, on every sale. Examples: Meesho, Zomato, Swiggy, Urban Company.

How it earns. Commission. Two terms matter. **GMV** (Gross Merchandise Value) is the total value of everything sold on the platform. **Take rate** is the share of GMV the company keeps.

Example. Buyers spend ₹100 crore on a marketplace in a month, so GMV is ₹100 crore. The take rate is 20%, so the company's own revenue is ₹20 crore, not ₹100 crore.

Analysis expected. Two sides must both be happy. Buyers need to find what they want fast, and sellers need to get orders. So the data covers both: orders, cancellations, delivery time, and how many sellers are active.

SaaS (Software as a Service)

A company that sells software for a monthly or yearly fee instead of a one-time price. You will also see it written "SaaS". Examples: Zoho, Freshworks, Notion.

How it earns. Subscriptions. **MRR** (Monthly Recurring Revenue) is the money it earns every month from subscriptions. **Churn** is the share of customers who cancel in a period.

Example. 100 customers each pay ₹10,000 a month, so MRR is ₹10 lakh. If 5 customers cancel this month, churn is 5%.

Analysis expected. Do customers keep paying? How many use the product after the free trial? How much money comes in each month, and how long will cash last?

The same role, three different jobs

Role	D2C	Marketplace	SaaS
Founder's Office	Which products and channels make real profit after all costs?	Are buyers and sellers both growing, and does our commission cover costs?	Is monthly recurring revenue growing, and how long will cash last?

Role	D2C	Marketplace	SaaS
Chief of Staff	Are monthly sales and profit targets on track across sales, stock and ads?	Are goals on track across buyers, sellers, and delivery speed?	Are goals on track for new subscriptions, renewals, and support quality?
Program Manager	Launch a new product or warehouse on time, with stock ready	Open new cities: sign up sellers, hire, go live by a date	Onboard a big customer or release a new feature across teams on time
Product Manager	Where do shoppers drop off before paying?	Can buyers find what they want quickly?	Which features do users actually use, and do they stay after the trial?
Growth Manager	How do we make one-time buyers come back?	How do we grow both sides: more buyers ordering, more sellers listing?	How do free-trial users become paying, and then upgrade?
Acquisition Manager	Cost of winning a buyer on Instagram or Google, and sales per ad rupee	Two costs to track: new buyers and new sellers	Cost per trial signup and per paying customer
Category Manager	Which products earn good margin, and which just sit in the warehouse?	Which sellers and products to feature or drop, and are our prices competitive?	Pricing and packaging: which plans and add-ons to sell, and at what price?
Demand Planner	How many units to make or buy, without piling up unsold stock	Are there enough sellers, riders or stock in each area at peak time?	Little physical stock, so planning is for support staff, servers and onboarding capacity

6. Jargon buster

Every word used in this pre-read, in plain language. Come back to this table whenever a word feels fuzzy.

Word	What it means	Tiny example
Data	Information written in rows and columns	An attendance register
Header	The name at the top of a column	"order_value"
Metric	A number with a name that shows if something is going well	Attendance %
Stakeholder	Anyone who uses your analysis or is affected by it	The founder, the sales head
Funnel	The steps users take, with fewer people at each step	1,000 open the app, 100 pay
Conversion rate	Share of people who complete a step	100 pay out of 1,000 who opened: 10%
Retention	Share of customers who are still active after some time	40 of 100 January joiners still order in March
Repeat rate	Share of customers who buy more than once	30 of 100 buyers ordered twice or more: 30%
Cohort	A group of customers who joined in the same period	Everyone who signed up in January
Churn	Share of customers who leave in a period	5 of 100 cancel this month: 5%
CAC	Customer Acquisition Cost: ad spend divided by new customers	₹50,000 spent, 100 new customers: ₹500

Word	What it means	Tiny example
CTR	Click-Through Rate: share of people who saw an ad and clicked	20 clicks on 1,000 views: 2%
CPC	Cost Per Click: ad spend divided by clicks	₹1,000 spent, 100 clicks: ₹10
ROAS	Return On Ad Spend: sales from ads divided by ad spend	₹3 lakh sales from ₹1 lakh ads: 3
GMV	Gross Merchandise Value: total value of goods sold on a platform	₹100 crore
Take rate	The share of GMV the platform keeps as revenue	20% of ₹100 crore is ₹20 crore
MRR / ARR	Monthly / Annual Recurring Revenue from subscriptions	100 customers × ₹10,000: ₹10 lakh MRR
Burn	Money the company spends each month beyond what it earns	₹40 lakh a month
Runway	How many months the cash will last at the current burn	₹2 crore cash ÷ ₹40 lakh burn: 5 months
Unit economics	Profit or loss on one single order or customer	₹150 left per earphone sold
Lead time	Days between placing an order with a supplier and receiving it	2 days
Forecast	A reasoned guess about the future	"We will sell 300 packets on Sunday"
Stockout	A product is unavailable when a customer wants it	Milk shelf empty at 6 p.m.
Days of cover	How many days current stock will last at the current sales speed	600 packets ÷ 200 a day: 3 days
Goal tracker	A sheet listing each goal, its target and its progress	"Sales: target ₹5 crore, done ₹3.5 crore"

New words from the role cards and the metrics table

Word	What it means	Tiny example
D2C (Direct-to-Consumer)	A brand that makes its own products and sells straight to customers	Mamaearth selling on its own app
Marketplace	A platform where many sellers meet many buyers, and the platform takes a cut	Meesho
SaaS	Software you rent by paying a monthly or yearly fee	Zoho
Commission	The cut a platform keeps from each sale	20% of a ₹500 order is ₹100
Category	A group of similar products	Dairy, Kurtis, Earphones
Channel	A route that brings customers in	Instagram ads, Google search, a friend's referral
Traffic / Visits	The number of people who open the app or site	10,000 visits today
Organic vs Paid	Organic customers come on their own (search, friends). Paid customers come through ads	60 organic and 40 paid out of 100 new customers
Referral rate / K-factor	How many new users each existing user brings in	Each user brings 0.3 friends: K-factor is 0.3
Activation rate	Share of new users who do the key first action	40 of 100 new users place a first order: 40%

Word	What it means	Tiny example
Feature adoption	Share of users who use a given feature	25 of 100 users tap the "reorder" button: 25%
Order frequency	How many orders a customer places in a month	3 orders a month
DAU / MAU and Stickiness	Daily Active Users divided by Monthly Active Users. It shows how many of your monthly users show up every day, which is called stickiness	2,000 daily ÷ 10,000 monthly: 20%
Reactivation rate	Share of sleeping users (who went quiet) that you win back	10 of 100 sleeping users order again: 10%
AOV (Average Order Value)	Total sales divided by the number of orders	₹3,00,000 from 1,000 orders: ₹300
Basket size (units per order)	The number of items in a typical order	2.5 items per order
Cross-selling	Suggesting extra items along with the main one	"Add fries?" when you order a burger
Net revenue	What the company actually keeps, after discounts, refunds and the sellers' share	₹20 crore kept out of ₹100 crore GMV
Margin / Gross margin %	The share of the selling price left after paying for the product itself	Sell at ₹100, product costs ₹60: 40%
Variable costs	Costs that grow with every order. Fixed costs, like rent, stay the same	Packing and delivery fee
Contribution margin	Profit on one order after the variable costs	₹500 order, ₹400 of variable costs: ₹100
P&L (Profit and Loss)	A summary of money earned minus money spent	Earned ₹10 lakh, spent ₹8 lakh: ₹2 lakh profit
LTV (Lifetime Value)	Total profit a customer brings while they stay with you	₹150 profit per order × 4 orders: ₹600
LTV : CAC ratio	LTV divided by CAC. It shows how much a customer is worth compared with what it cost to win them	LTV ₹600, CAC ₹200: 3 to 1
CAC payback	Months needed to earn back the cost of winning a customer	CAC ₹300, profit ₹100 a month: 3 months
Availability (in-stock rate)	Share of the time an item is in stock when someone looks for it	In stock 90 times out of 100: 90%
Forecast accuracy	How close the forecast was to what really sold	Guessed 100, sold 90: off by 10%
Dead stock	Stock that is not selling	500 winter jackets still unsold in June
Milestone	A checkpoint on the way to finishing a project	"Warehouse ready by 15 March"
On-scope	Delivered everything that was promised	All 5 cities launched, not just 3
Operating rhythm	The regular meetings and reviews that keep a company running	The weekly business review
Experiment	A small test to learn what works	₹50 off the second order for half of the new users